Coraline

By Neil Gaiman

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR 1:*** *Coraline, Child 2*
ACTOR 2: *Narrator, Mrs. Spink, COM (Crazy Old Man), Mother, Father, Other Mother, Policeman, Cat, Child 1, Other COM*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NARRATOR: **(Pg 1-2)** It was a very old house and Coraline's family didn't own all of [it] - it was too big for that. Instead they owned part of it. Miss Spink lived in the flat below . . .

MRS. SPINK: You see, Caroline . . .

CORALINE: It's Coraline, Not Caroline. Coraline

MRS. SPINK: *(waving the interruption away with her hand)* [I was] a famous actress in my time. I trod the boards, luvvy!

NARRATOR: . . . and in the flat above was a crazy old man with a big mustache.

COM: One day, little Caroline . . .

CORALINE: It's Coraline, Not Caroline. Coraline

COM: . . . *(waving the interruption away with his hand)* When they are all ready, everyone in the whole world will see the wonders of my mouse circus! The mice are not yet ready. They refuse the play the songs I have written for them. They go ***oompah oompah***; but the white mice will only play ***toodle oodle***, like that! I am thinking of trying them on different types of cheese . . . *(Listens intently to a mouse held in his hand, then whispers in an ominous voice)* **(Pg 14)** The mice have a message for you: ***"Don't go through the door . . ."***

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Not since Narnia has the simple act of opening a door unlocked such a fantastic journey.*
ACTOR 2: *And not since Alice tumbled down the rabbit hole has that journey been so splendidly strange and frightening.*
ACTOR 1: *Caroline will have to fight with all her wits and courage if she is to save herself and return to her ordinary life.*
TOGETHER: *Coraline by Neil Gaiman*

NARRATOR: **(Pg 2,4,1)** The day after they moved in, Coraline went exploring. She explored the garden and the grounds. She explored every day until the day it rained, when Coraline had to stay inside.

CORALINE: **(Pg 4-6)** What should I do?

MOTHER: *(busily typing on her keyboard)* Read a book. Watch a video. Play with your toys. Go and pester Miss Spink or the crazy mold man upstairs.

CORALINE: I don't want to do those things. I want to explore!

NARRATOR: It was time to talk to her father.

CORALINE: It's raining. Can I go outside?

FATHER: *(busily typing on his keyboard)* What does your mother say?

CORALINE: *(mimicking her mother's voice)* You're not going out in weather like that, Coraline Jones. But I want to carry on exploring.

FATHER: *(frustrated and impatient)* Then explore the flat. Count all the doors and windows. List everything blue. And leave me alone to work.

CORALINE: *(keeping track of everything on a sheet of paper)* Everything blue – 153; Windows – 21; Doors . . .

NARRATOR: **(Pg 1)** [It was then that] Coraline discovered THE door. **(Pg 6-7)** The big, carved, wooden door at the far corner of the drawing room. It was locked.

CORALINE: *(to Mother)* Where does that door go?

MOTHER: Nowhere, dear. *(angry at the interruption, grumpily takes a string of keys, selects the oldest key and unlocks the door. Coraline watches excitedly and then is disappointed)*

NARRATOR: Her mother was right. The door didn't go anywhere. It opened onto a brick wall.

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COM.: **(Pg 14)** *(whispering)* Don't go through the door!

CORALINE: **(Pg 16)** *(confused at the ominous whisper from nowhere, releases a heavy disappointed sigh and goes to find her father again)* . . . *(to her father)* I'm bored. Why don't you play with me?

FATHER: Busy . . . Working . . .Why don't you go and bother Miss Spink?

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MRS. SPINK: Oh, it's you, Caroline

CORALINE: **(Pg 2)** It's Coraline, Not Caroline. Coraline

MRS. SPINK: **(Pg 16-19)** Come in dear. Would you like a cup of tea? *(pours a cup and hands it to Coraline. Coraline takes a sip and Mrs. Spink grabs the teacup)* I'll read the leaves. I'll read your future. *(peers into the cup, then says ominously)* You are in terrible danger.

CORALINE: What am I in danger from? What should I do?

MRS. SPINK: Be very, very careful!

NARRATOR: She reaches into her pocket and takes out a stone with a hole in it.

MRS. SPINK: [This] might help. *(hands it to Coraline, who holds it up to the light and peers through the hole)* They're good for bad things . . . sometimes.

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CORALINE: *(bored again, wanders back into her part of the house and over to THE door. She turned the doorknob, and instead of a brick wall behind the door, there is a dark hallway.*

OTHER MOTHER: **(Pg 26-28)** Coraline? Is that you? Lunchtime . . .

CORALINE: Who are you?

OTHER MOTHER: I'm your other mother.

CORALINE: *(confused)* I didn't know I had another mother.

OTHER MOTHER: Of course, you do. Everyone does. It wasn't the same here without you; but [I] knew you'd arrive one day, and then we could be a proper family. **(Pg 43-45)** You can stay here for ever and always. If you want to. *(puts her hand on Coraline's shoulder)*

MRS SPINK: **(Pg 18)** You are in terrible danger.

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CORALINE: **(Pg 43-45)** *(pulling away, scared and nervous)* I'm going now. *(reaches into her pocket and pulls out the stone with a hole in it)*

OTHER MOTHER: *(her hand scuttles off Coraline's shoulder like a frightened spider)* If that's what you want. Come back soon . . . then we'll be together . . . for ever and always!

CORALINE: *(backing away, hurries through the door back into her own house and searches for her Mother and Father)* Mom?? Dad?? *(they are nowhere to be found)* **(Pg 51)** Where are they? **(Pg 52-53)** I suppose there is only one thing left to do. *(picks up the phone, searches phone book for the number and dials)*

POLICEMAN: Police

CORALINE: Hello. My name is Coraline Jones. I am ringing to report a crime. Kidnapping. Grown-up-napping really. My parents have been stolen away.

POLICEMAN: *(humoring her)* And do you know who stole them?

CORALINE: I think my ***other*** mother has them in her clutches. She may want to keep them in order to lure me back. I'm not sure.

POLICEMAN: *(chuckling)* Ah, the nefarious clutches, is it? Mmm. Ask your mother to make you a mug of hot chocolate and give you a great big old hug. *(hangs up)*

CORALINE: **(Pg 57)** *(realizing she's on her own . . . returns to THE door, places her hand on the knob, hesitates, gives herself a pep talk)* When you're scared, but you still do it anyway, that's ***brave***.

COM: **(Pg 14)** *(whispering)* Don't go through the door!

MRS. SPINK: **(Pg 18)** You are in terrible danger.

CORALINE: **(Pg 57)** *(arguing with the voices)* They are my parents. If they noticed I was gone, I'm sure they would do the same for me. *(opens the door and enters the other world)*

OTHER MOTHER: **(Pg 58-62)** Coraline? Darling? *(embraces Caroline in a desperate hug)* Why did you ever run away from me.

CORALINE: *(breaking free)* Where are my parents?!

OTHER MOTHER: I'm here. I'm ready to love you and play with you and feed you and make your life interesting. *(a creepy smile)*

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CORALINE: You don't frighten me *(pulls the stone from her pocket and uses it to ward off her other mother)* I want my parents back!

OTHER MOTHER: *(recoiling from the stone)* Whatever would I have done with your old parents? If they have left you, Coraline, it must be because they became bored with you.

CORALINE: You're lying. You stole them.

OTHER MOTHER: Please, don't be difficult. I am going back to bed, Coraline . . . I would strongly suggest that you do the same. *(exits)*

CORALINE: *(tries the door, but it won't open. A cat enters, and she speaks to it, not expecting an answer)* Why does she want me? Why does she want me to stay here with her?

CAT: **(Pg 63)** She wants something to love, I think *(reacts with shock and awe, but then accepts this strange occurrence)* Something that isn't her. She might want something to eat as well. It's hard to tell with creatures like that.

CORALINE: Do you have any advice?

CAT: Challenge her. There's no guarantee she'll play fair, but her kind of thing loves games and challenges . . . **(Pg 36)** By the by. It was sensible of you to bring protection. I'd hang on to it, if I were you. *(exits)*

CORALINE: Protection . . . *(Coraline pulls the stone from her pocket, rubs it for luck and returns it to her pocket)*

OTHER MOTHER: **(Pg 75-77)** *(enters)* Coraline, my darling. I thought we could play some games together. Hopscotch? Happy Families? Monopoly? What game should we play.

CORALINE: I don't want to play with you. I want to go home and be with my real parents. I want you to let them go. To let us all go!

OTHER MOTHER: *(tilts her head, purses her lips angrily)* Manners! *(grabs Coraline's arm and pulls her to the end of the hall, opens a small door and pushes her inside)* You may come out when you've learned some manners. And when you're ready to be a loving daughter.

MRS. SPINK: **(Pg 18)** You are in terrible danger.

CORALINE: **(Pg 79-84)** *(begins to cry but then notices 2 other children also locked inside)*

CHILD 1: *(in a whisper)* Hush! And Shush! Say nothing, for the beldam might be listening!

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CHILD 2: Art thou – ***alive***?

CORALINE: *(also in a hushed voice)* What happened to you. How did you come here?

CHILDREN'S VOICES TOGETHER: She left us here. She stole our hearts, and she stole our souls, she took our lives away, and she forgot about us in the dark. Flee while you still have your mind and your soul.

CORALINE: I'm not running away. She has my parents. I came back to get them.

CHILD 1: If you could win your mamma and your papa back from the beldam, you could also free our souls.

CORALINE: Has she taken them?

CHILDREN'S VOICES TOGETHER: And hidden them. That is why we could not leave here when we died. She kept us, and she fed on us, until now we've nothing left of ourselves. Flee!

CORALINE: She won't keep me in the dark forever. She brought me here to play games. ***Games and challenges***, the cat said. *(hears a rustling at the door)*

OTHER MOTHER: **(Pg 87-90)** *(opening the door)* There, my sweet Coraline. You needed to be taught a lesson. Now, if you will be a good child who loves her mother. *(gestures that Coraline may come out)*

CHILDREN'S VOICES TOGETHER: Look through the stone *(their voices echo)*

CORALINE: *(as she climbs out of the small room)* You like games. That's what I've been told.

OTHER MOTHER: *(intrigued)* Everybody likes games.

CORALINE: Yes. Wouldn't you be happier if you won me, fair and square?

OTHER MOTHER: Possibly. What exactly are you offering?

CORALINE: Me. If I lose I'll stay here with you forever and I'll let you love me. I'll be a most dutiful daughter. I'll eat your food and play Happy Families.

OTHER MOTHER: That sounds very fine. And if you do not lose?

CORALINE: Then you let me go. You let everyone go – my real father and mother, the children [in that room] . . . everyone you've trapped here.

OTHER MOTHER: What kind of game shall it be? A riddle? A test of knowledge?

CORALINE: An exploring game. A finding-things game.

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OTHER MOTHER: And what is it you should be finding, Coraline Jones?

CORALINE: My parents . . and the souls of the children.

OTHER MOTHER: Deal!

NARRATOR: **(Pg 92)** Caroline looked around the kitchen. She opened the oven, peered into the freezer and poked into the refrigerator.

CHILD 2: **(Pg 85)** Look through the stone

CORALINE: **(Pg 93)** *(puts her hand in her pocket, pulls out the stone with a hole in it and peers though the hole. She wanders up the stairs, still peering through the stone)*

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(Pg 116-118) *(Coraline has entered the other world rooms of the Crazy Old Man)*

OTHER COM: Nothing's changed, little girl. [If you win] You'll go home. You'll be bored. You'll be ignored. They don't even get your name right. Stay here with us. Your other mother will build whole worlds for you to explore. If you stay here, you can have whatever you want.

CORALINE: *(sighing)* You really don't understand, do you? I don't want whatever I want. Nobody does. What kind of fun would it be if I just got everything I ever wanted. You're just a bad copy she made of the crazy old man upstairs.

CAT: **(Pg 133)** Come on! This is not a good place to be! Quickly!

CHILD 2: **(Pg 85)** Look through the stone

NARRATOR: **(Pg 133-134)** *(Peering through her stone, Coraline acts out the following)* Coraline began to run. Winds howled. She could hear the cat padding in the dark in front of her. She reached the door. It was open. She staggered through it and slammed it behind her with the loudest bang you can imagine.

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(scene opens with Coraline sleeping on the floor just outside THE door. Her real mother gently shaking her to wake her up)

MOTHER: *(in a non-nonsense tone)* Coraline? What a funny place to fall asleep. We looked all over the house for you. Dinner in fifteen minutes. Don't forget to wash your hands.

(Coraline gives her Mother a huge hug)

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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
2023 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MI State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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